CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

MAKEUP ARTIST IN THE AI ERA

There is no makeup-artist job in the federal data. There's a 4,300-job film occupation — and an unlicensed gig market.

★ **TL;DR — NO — the card cannot be priced as framed, so here is the split, plainly. BLS's handbook has no makeup-artist occupation at all; the only BLS wage (SOC 39-5091, theatrical and performance) is $97,150 across just ~4,300 jobs — union film and theatre work a beginner can't walk into. The everyday market a 2027 starter actually faces (bridal, events, retail) is unlicensed gig work starting at $50–$200 a booking — below the $45K this card claimed, a figure that almost certainly came from Skincare Specialists ($45,330). The roadmap below is the way OUT.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$97K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

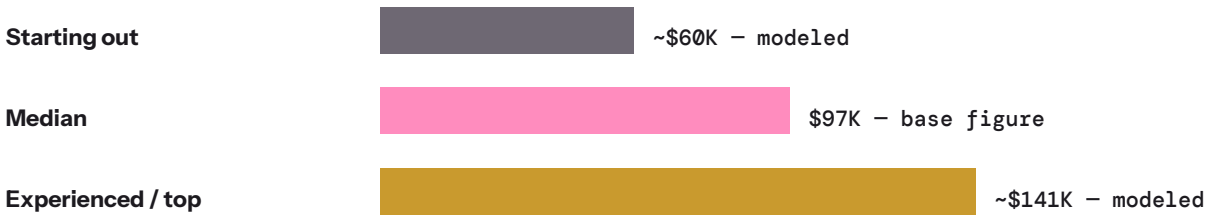
- Fails as a start because: there is no first job — no licence, no employer ladder, no programme that gates anything. Entry is portfolio, assisting and self-generated gigs, with student and short films paying $0–$150/day, explicitly for the portfolio.

- The $97K figure is a trap in the opposite direction: a bimodal union distribution (10th percentile □ $23,360; 90th □ $167,470) over 4,300 jobs growing by ~300 in a decade, inside a film industry down roughly 30% from its late-2022 employment peak.

- Still worth money: face skill, colour judgment and set etiquette are exactly what licensed skin work and permanent makeup monetise — with permits, tiers and $400–$800 tickets attached.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Makeup Artist is a ~$97K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A MAKEUP ARTIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Consult on looks: skin prep, color, style matched to the event and the camera
- ✓ Apply makeup for weddings, shoots, sets and special occasions
- ✓ Maintain strict hygiene: cleaned brushes, sanitized products, disposable tools
- ✓ Build and haul a professional kit that covers every skin tone and type

Think: a painter whose canvas talks, sweats, cries at weddings and checks the mirror — hired by the day, if the phone rings.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Virtual try-on (L'Oréal's ModiFace powers Sephora's Virtual Artist) erodes the retail-counter advisor role — a genuine beginner rung — and filters reset what clients expect skin to look like. Booking, portfolios and payments run on apps. None of it applies physical makeup at a wedding.	Skin is physical: texture, undertones, tears, heat, twelve-hour wear. Application skill plus a calm chair-side manner is entirely human. The problem was never the craft — it's that nobody is structurally hired to do it at the start.

⚠ **Two fictions to retire: the $45K 'median after a certificate' (no such BLS figure exists for this work) and the 6–12-month programme as a requirement (nothing gates makeup application — in most states it's explicitly unlicensed; licences attach to skin and hair services, not makeup). A school selling a makeup certificate as a licence to work is selling paper. The honest high end: IATSE Local 706 scale ($54.63/hr; Department Head $69.91/hr, plus kit rental) is real money — behind a union roster earned through production work you can't yet get.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Creative, social, transformation work ✓ You are present at people's happiest days ✓ Freelance control over clients and calendar	✗ 5 a.m. wedding calls and weekend marathons ✗ Kit costs: quality products are not cheap, and they're yours ✗ Weeks of unpaid portfolio work between paid days

Good fit? You already assist working artists, have a portfolio that books, and treat gigs as a business you're building over years.
Bad fit? You need a programme to hand you a job and a median to plan rent on — neither exists here.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Esthetician	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Permanent Makeup Artist
Your brushes become licensed instruments: BLS median $45,330 (Skincare Specialists), growth +9%, ~14,200 openings a year, 90th percentile $82,050 via master/advanced tiers and physician-office settings (~$51,600 median). Facials, peels and device work sit under a state licence employers actually hire against. First move: a 600–750-hour esthetics programme — and keep assisting artists on weekends while you train, so the portfolio grows next to a licence.	The same face, implanted instead of applied: $400–$800 tickets, annual touch-ups ($200–$400) as built-in repeat business, ~$55K labelled gross average (ZipRecruiter 2021; no official median exists). Regulated as body art — permit, bloodborne-pathogens training, supervised procedures — which is precisely the moat freelance makeup lacks. The industry's own academy says the current shakeout removes the under-trained, not the demand. First move: a 100-hour+ fundamental course, not a weekend intensive.

Smart move: Attach your face skill to a licence. Unlicensed talent competes with every creator on earth; licensed pigment and device work competes with a short, shrinking list.
Where you land after: You land where face work is permitted, tiered and rebooked on a schedule — skin outcomes and year-long pigment instead of one-day gigs.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
SPLIT THE	PRICE THE	PICK YOUR	KEEP THE	TRAIN INTO	LET GIGS

STEP 1 — Split the two markets

FREE · TODAY

- Write the SOC facts: 4,300 jobs, $97,150 median, ~+300 jobs in a decade
- Write the gig facts: $50–$200 beginner bookings, $0–$150/day student films — that's your actual market

STEP 2 — Price the unpaid layer

WEEK 1

- Count the portfolio, assisting and kit-building months at near-zero income
- If the runway isn't there, the gig market isn't either

STEP 3 — Pick your door

WEEK 2

- Door A: esthetics — your face skill under a state licence with tiers
- Door B: permanent makeup — your face skill as licensed pigment with repeat demand

STEP 4 — Keep the portfolio, add the permit

WEEKS 2-6

- Your makeup portfolio is the application asset for both doors — keep shooting faces
- Map your state's esthetics licence or body-art registration requirements in writing

STEP 5 — Train into the licensed seat

WEEKS 4-12

- Esthetics: 600–750 hours. PMU: a 100-hour+ fundamental with supervised procedures
- Judge programmes by supervised practice and healed results, not marketing

STEP 6 — Let gigs ride on top

ONGOING

- Weddings and shoots become premium side income once a licensed base pays the rent
- Gig-first is the lottery; licence-first is the business

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: write the two columns — 4,300 union jobs vs the gig market you're actually entering.
- □ Days 1–30: runway counted; door chosen; state licence/registration rules mapped in writing.
- □ Days 31–60: training underway; weekend assisting continues for portfolio and contacts.
- □ Days 61–90: supervised practice accumulating; first licensed-seat targets identified.
- □ Day 90: your face skill is attached to a permit and a ladder — gigs optional, not survival.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

· Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **SKILL NEEDS A LICENCE TO PAY.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.